St. Bernard
Happenings
Summer 2026

St. Bernard Hosts 127th Commencement Ceremonies

Under blue skies temperatures nearing 90 degrees, the stirring melodies of bagpipes drifted across the grounds of the beautifully adorned Abbey Church as St. Bernard Preparatory School celebrated its 127th Commencement Exercises on Sunday, May 17, 2026. Family members, faculty, alumni, and friends filled the church to honor and celebrate the graduating Class of 2026. The commencement ceremony was presided over by President Fr. Joel Martin, while Chaplain Cletus D. Meagher offered the invocation.

One of the highlights of the afternoon was the presentation of the Distinguished Alumnus Award to John M. Dowd, a graduate from St. Bernard College, Class of 1963. After serving in the United States Marine Corps, Dowd became a nationally recognized attorney while working in the United States Department of Justice. Afterwards, he was asked to investigate Pete Rose and gambling in Major League Baseball. Many may remember Dowd because of the "Dowd Report," which proved this to be a fact. Throughout his career, high-profile leaders, including United States Senators, State Governors, and the President of the United States, acknowledged Dowd's exceptional abilities. It is an honor for St. Bernard to recognize this remarkable alumnus and his abundant accomplishments.

The Distinguished Young Alumnus Award was presented to Casey L. Daniel, (PS'03), who also delivered the Commencement Address. Dr. Daniel is widely respected for her work in cancer prevention, early detection, and survivorship research, particularly in pediatric, colorectal, and skin cancers. A graduate of Birmingham-Southern College, she earned both her Master of Public Health and Ph.D. from the University of Alabama at Birmingham before completing postdoctoral fellowships at the Harvard School of Public Health and the Dana-Farber Cancer Institute. She currently serves as a researcher and educator at the University of South Alabama.

In her soft-spoken address, Daniel reflected on her own cancer diagnosis during her senior year of high school and the determination that carried her through treatment, doctor visits, and ultimately into a career devoted to helping others.

"Let me say to each one of you," Daniel told graduates, "I was not Valedictorian or Salutatorian or may not have been in the top of my class, but I knew I wanted to kick cancer, and I didn't want anyone else to have to endure what I faced at such an early age."

Her powerful message of perseverance and purpose resonated deeply throughout the church and served as a moving reminder of the impact one life can have on others.

Academic honors were also recognized during the ceremony. Parker Guthery was named Salutatorian, while Sarah Jane Woods earned the distinction of Valedictorian as well as the General Excellence Award.

Following the presentation of diplomas, Valedictorian Sarah Woods addressed her classmates. Graduates then joined together in singing the school alma mater before the ceremony concluded with a final prayer and dismissal.

Music for the afternoon was provided by Jacob Emmanuel Viola, Titular Organist of St. Bernard Abbey, while the ceremonial bagpipe music was performed by Alabama Pipes and Drums.

Following the ceremony, graduates and guests gathered for a reception in the Abbey Church.



Graduation Honors
Fr. Dominic Lee, Valedictorian Sarah Woods, Salutatorian Parker Guthery, Phuong Nguyen, and Fr. Joel Martin



Front row (l-r): *Mariella Tombo, Kimberly McCormick, Rachel Bennett, and Anna Agnello.* **Second row (l-r):** *Sarah Woods, Kaitlyn Chamblee, Emma Osborne, and Charli Roberson.* **Third row (l-r):** *Daniel Pichardo, Gavitt Lewis, Alex Chavez, and Benedict Gil.* **Back row (l-r):** *Parker Guthery, Joshua Marks, Luke Baney, and Luke Daly.*



Joyce Nix

Bloomin' Festival Director Joyce Nix Set to Retire June 30

For 42 years, if something important was happening at St. Bernard Preparatory School, chances were good that Joyce Nix was right in the middle of it — clutching her famous 15-month calendar book, answering phone calls, greeting visitors by name, planning the next big event, and somehow still finding time to keep everyone around her smiling and laughing.

Effective June 30, 2026, Joyce Nix will retire from St. Bernard Prep. When Joyce first arrived in 1983, St. Bernard was much smaller, leaner, and operating largely on faith, determination, and Benedictine grit. Over the next four decades, she became one of the school's greatest storytellers and strongest champions, helping guide its growth while preserving the spirit that made the institution unique. She did this while serving St. Bernard Prep in many roles, including admissions director, business manager, founder and director of festivals, and director of marketing and public relations.

"I have met many wonderful people during my time at St. Bernard. It has been a gratifying experience to be part of building a school from the ground up, and to share our student successes. I have been blessed to know each one," Nix said.

(Continued on page 2)

St. Bernard Happenings

2026 Bloomin' Festival Surpasses Fundraising Goal

Warm, sunny skies and temperatures in the high 80s set the stage for the kickoff of the 42nd Annual Bloomin' Festival at St. Bernard Preparatory School, drawing enthusiastic crowds eager to experience one of the region's premier arts and crafts events.

Festival patrons stayed refreshed with offerings like Pepsi and fresh-squeezed lemonade available throughout campus, while browsing an impressive selection of high-quality, handcrafted goods from artists across the Southeastern United States. Items ranged from brooms, ironwork, and copper pieces to pottery, birdhouses, wood-turned pens, cutting boards, clothing, jewelry, furniture, swings, and more.



Festival Winner Christopher Metress is congratulated by Fr. Joel Martin after winning the Grand Prize 2026 Buick Encore at the Bloomin' Festival April 19

The success of the festival was made possible through the dedicated efforts of St. Bernard faculty, parents, students, monks, alumni, and friends, all of whom volunteered their time to ensure a seamless experience for visitors.

"It's always a good thing when setting up in the sunshine on Friday, but it's even better when the birds are chirping, and the sun is out on Saturday," said Festival Director Joyce Nix with a smile.

Weather conditions shifted Saturday evening as heavy wind and rain swept through the area, causing some damage to several vendor tents. But the resilience of the festival community was evident. Vendors, used to living with Alabama weather, regrouped quickly on Sunday, ready to continue the event.

At 4 p.m. on Sunday, the festival concluded with the highly anticipated sweepstakes drawing. Seven-year-old Charlie Tucker of Cullman assisted Fr. Joel with the drawings. All four winners hailed from Birmingham, Alabama:

Christopher Metress — 2026 Buick Encore

Deacon Wally Zieverink — Dyson Vacuum Cleaner

Antoine Huerto Garcia — Blackstone Griddle

Janie Mauter — Apple AirPods

Festival organizers extended their gratitude to all attendees, vendors, volunteers, and sponsors who contributed to the event's success. Special thanks were given to sponsors including Senator Garlan Gudger, Bill Smith Buick GMC, Cantey Foundation Specialist, Cypress Roofing, Leaf Filter, Mitch Smith Chevrolet, Nanny's Lemonade, O.F. Richter & Sons, Inc., Renewal by Anderson, Weichert Realty, Cutco, Eidson & Associates, Inc., Pepsi, Citizens Bank & Trust, Kassouf & Co., Merchants Bank, Modernistic, Visit Cullman, Wal-Mart Distribution, Comfort Suites, Cullman Jefferson Gas, Higginbotham Insurance, Jewelers Cut Pawn, Legacy, Redstone Federal Credit Union, Holly's Nail & Spa, and Signature Smiles.

"We had a $250,000 goal, and thanks to everyone, we surpassed our goal," Nix said.

The Bloomin' Festival continues to stand as a testament to community spirit, craftsmanship, and the enduring support of those who believe in the mission of St. Bernard Preparatory School.



Theresa Heffner, Hayden, Stain glass vendor at Bloomin' Festival

Nix Set to Retire June 30 after 42 Years as Bloomin' Festival Founding Director

(Continued from page 1)

Many throughout Alabama and beyond know Joyce best as the founding director of Bloomin' Festival. For 42 years, she transformed what began as a modest idea into one of the South's most treasured spring traditions. Artists, shoppers, volunteers, alumni, and visitors quickly learned that Bloomin' Festival did not simply happen—it succeeded because Joyce made it happen.

As if that accomplishment were not enough, Joyce also launched Bernard Blues a decade ago, creating another signature event centered around blues music, arts and crafts, and barbecue. Between organizing vendors, managing endless details, solving last-minute problems, and ensuring every guest felt welcomed, she mastered the art of orchestrating "controlled chaos" with grace and humor.

"I have always enjoyed traveling to other shows in and outside of Alabama, inviting people to Cullman. Our artists at St. Bernard are not just participants; they are my people, and I will miss them, but I know they will be taken care of by whoever fills my position, "assured Nix.

Friends and coworkers often joked that Joyce knew where "all the bones were buried." She knew donors by name, artists by name, and often anticipated problems before they surfaced. Beyond the festivals and special events, Joyce became one of the school's greatest ambassadors. She welcomed generations of students, parents, alumni, and guests with loyalty, humor, and genuine warmth. Her dedication to the mission of St. Bernard was never superficial—it was deeply personal and rooted in a sincere love for the school community.

In her retirement announcement, Joyce reflected not only on the school's growth but also on the importance of stewardship, accountability, unity, and excellence. Even in retirement, her hopes remain firmly centered on the continued success of the institution she devoted most of her life to serving.

Reflecting on Joyce Nix's retirement, Fr. Joel Martin, President of St. Bernard Prep, had much to say. "Joyce Nix and St. Bernard Prep have been together for almost 43 years, and for those years Joyce has been the school's rep for most who think of St. Bernard. And after all that time, Joyce comes to work daily excited about her new plans to improve the school and its community; you'd think it was her first week on the job. In the last few weeks, she interviewed every graduating senior of 2026, and for each she wrote a delightful article that captured the uniqueness of the person. She was not assigned to do this; she simply knew it would be good to do for the student and the school; that's Joyce Nix. God bless her for the gift she has been on this campus and beyond."

After 42 years, Joyce leaves behind countless friendships, immeasurable memories, and likely several Word and Excel files only she fully understands. As this extraordinary chapter comes to a close, Joyce leaves St. Bernard Preparatory School with deep gratitude, tremendous pride, and the quiet confidence that she is leaving the school better than she found it.



Pictured is Joyce Nix, Festival Director, and two of the first students to attend and graduate from St. Bernard Prep during its inaugural years, Andy (PS '89) and Chris (PS '88) Stangel of Florence, AL

St. Bernard Happenings



2026 St. Bernard Graduation



Fr. Joel Martin, Distinguished Young Alumna Dr. Casey Daniel, Commencement Speaker, and Br. Prior Brendan Seipel



Alabama Pipes and Drums



Charli Roberson and Rachel Bennett

St. Bernard Prep Hosts Academic Honors Banquet

St. Bernard Preparatory School proudly hosted its annual Academic Honors Banquet on Thursday, April 30, bringing together students, families, faculty, and distinguished guests in the Fazi-Richard Athletic Center to celebrate a year of exceptional academic accomplishment.

The evening began with a warm welcome and opening prayer from Fr. Joel Martin, President of St. Bernard Preparatory School, who commended students for their dedication to scholarship and the Benedictine values that guide their education.

A highlight of the evening was the presentation of scholarships to members of the Class of 2026. Robert Tidwell of Cullman Electric Cooperative presented the Cullman Electric $1,000 Scholarship to Josh Marks. Trace Beasley of the University of Alabama awarded scholarships to Sarah Woods, Charli Roberson, and Josh Marks.

Additional scholarship recipients included Kaitlyn Chamblee and Angel Daniel Pichardo-Luna, -University of South Alabama; Anna Agnello-University of Montevallo; and Kimberly McCormick, -University of Alabama at Birmingham. To date, the Senior Class of 2026 has been offered an impressive total of $5,870,000 in scholarships.

Guests enjoyed a delicious dinner of chicken piccata, green beans, and Alfredo pasta, generously sponsored by Kassouf of Birmingham, AL and prepared by Chef Thomas Maddux and the St. Bernard Dining Hall staff.

Following the scholarship presentations, students were recognized for outstanding academic achievement across all disciplines. The evening concluded with the presentation of two of the school's highest honors: the Benedictine Medal of Merit, awarded to Luke Daly, and the Christian Service Award, presented to Sarah Woods.

More photos on pages 4-6



Trace Beasley of the University of Alabama awarded scholarships to Sarah Woods, Charli Roberson, and Josh Marks.



Robert Tidwell of Cullman Electric Cooperative presented the Cullman Electric $1,000 Scholarship to Josh Marks.

St. Bernard Prep Hosts Academic Honors Banquet

(Continued from Page 3)



Art Awards: *Amber Watts, Instructor, Caroline Sanders, Analia Lajara, and Maria Agnello.*
Schola Awards: *Avery Hines, Karly Arndt,*



Schola Awards: *Avery Hines, Karly Arndt, Madison Rice, Vanesa Francisco and Sr. Thérèse Lopez.* **Back Row (l-r):** *Daniel Pichardo-Luna, Julia Yohe, Sean Daly, and Isabella Anderson.*

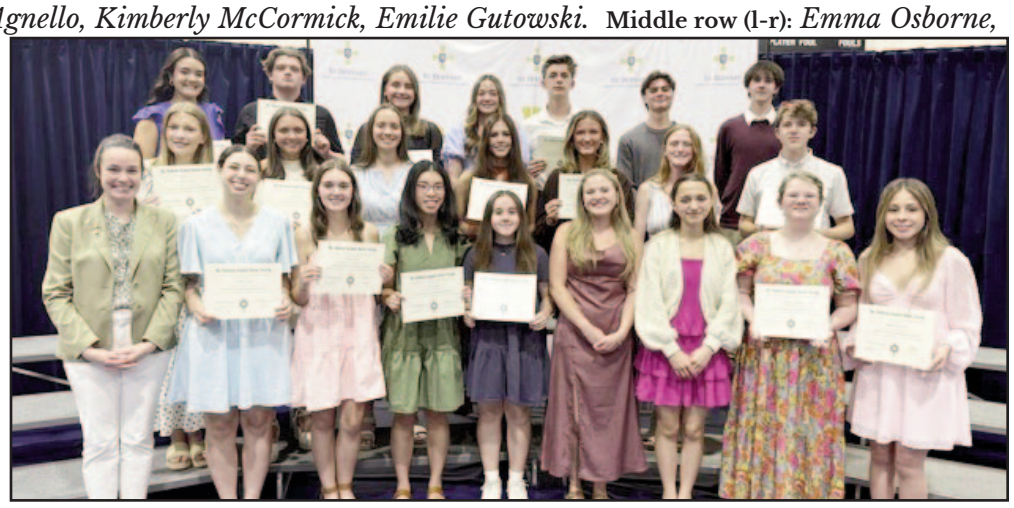


Thespian Arts: *Matthew Shaddrix, Instructor with Caterina Botta.*



Pre-AP English Awards: *Amber Watts, Instructor, Silas Krische, Murielle Pittet, and Chloe Brewer.*

English Awards: *Mrs. Ashley Hasenbein, Instructor, Ella Tombo, Karly Ardnt, Tessa Sanders, Alexis Cron, Anna Agnello, Kimberly McCormick, Emilie Gutowski.* **Middle row (l-r):** *Emma Osborne, Ruth Adams, Sarah Woods, Charlotte Boykin, Charli Roberson, Joy Lamote, and Kieran Gargen.* **Back row (l-r):** *Caroline McBride, Aiden Hays, Lily Tillitski, Katie Chamblee, Sean Daly, Parker Guthery, and Josh Marks.*



History Awards: *Dr. Craig Mann, Instructor, Saleen Mata, Murielle Pittet, and Chloe Brewer.*

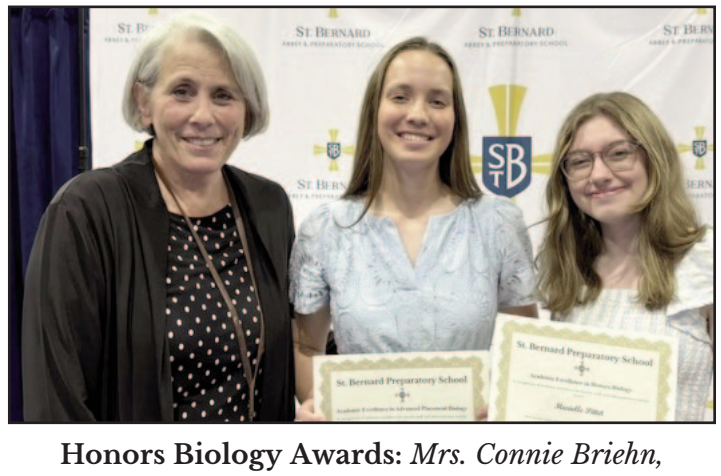




History Awards: *Ella Cron, Avery Hines, Vanesa Francisco, and Charlotte Boykin.* **Back row (l-r):** *James Griffin, Instructor, Sean Daly, Parker Guthery, Josh Marks, Sarah Woods, and Charli Roberson.*



History Awards: *Kimberly McCormick, Maria Agnello, Norah Bissot, Ella Cron, and Rafaella Guevara-Guardia.* **Back row (l-r):** *Matthew Shaddrix, Charlotte Boykin, Caterina Botta, Sarah Woods, Jacob Tombo, and Tessa Sanders.*



Honors Biology Awards: *Mrs. Connie Briehn, Sarah Woods and Murielle Pittet.*



Chemistry and Physiology Awards: *Mrs. Cassie Floyd, Rafi Guevara, Maria Agnello.* **Back row (l-r):** *Kaitlyn Chamblee, Karly Arndt, Lily Tillitski, and Jacob Tombo.*



Physics Awards: *Dr. Guy Smith, Isabella Anderson, and James Gillis.*



AP Physics Award: *Mr. Gilbert Alzona (substitute teacher) and Parker Guthery.*



Latin Awards: *Br. Damian, Emilie Gutowski, Norah Bissot, Chloe Brewer, Ella Cron, and Caroline Sanders.* **Middle row (l-r):** *Aaron Cortes-Villegas, Silas Krische, Avery Hines, and Jacob Tombo.* **Back row (l-r):** *Grayson Stewart, Andrew Nguyen, and Payton Becker.*



Spanish Awards: *Mrs. Rodriguez, Instructor, Alondra Martinez, and Saleen Mata.* **Back row (l-r):** *Anthony Ranelli, Judit Mejia, and Ingrid Ramirez Quintero.*



Algebra Awards: *Fr. Dominic Lee, Instructor, Ella Cron, and Norah Bissot.* **Back row (l-r):** *Silas Krische, Saleen Mata, and Payton Becker.*



Algebra Awards: *Kimberly McCormick, Maria Agnello, Josue Chavez and Alexis Cron.* **Back row (l-r):** *Mrs. Kim Whaley, Instructor, Kaitlyn Chamblee, Sean Daly, and Yufei Wang.*



Math Awards: *Mrs. Chanda Dabbs, Sarah Woods, Joy Lamote, Vanesa Francisco, and Parker Guthery.*



Mu Alpha Theta: *Lily Tillitski, Emilie Gutowski, Rafi Guevara, Ruth Adams, Tessa Sanders, and Karly Arndt.* **Back row (l-r):** *Caroline McBride, Sean Daly, Josh Marks, Parker Guthery, Sarah Woods, and Yufei Wang.*



Scholars Bowl: *Br. Thomas Jones, Saleen Mata*



Doves of the Altar: *Br. Thomas, Mariella Tombo, Vanesa Francisco, Norah Bissot, Kimberly McCormick.* **Back row (l-r):** *Sarah Woods, Charlotte Boykin, Caroline McBride, Julia Yohe, and Magnolia Donnelly.*



Knights of the Altar: *Fr. Joel Martin, President, Luke Daly (Grand Supreme Knight), Silas Krische, Aaron Cortes-Villegas, Cesar Blancas, Josue Chavez.* **Middle row (l-r);** *Kieran Gargan, Andrew Nguyen, Johnathan McBride, Jacob Tombo, Eugene Byrd.* **Back row (l-r):** *Benedict Gil, Josh Marks, Parker Guthery, James Gillis, Sean Daly and Aiden Hays.*

Athletic Awards



Fr. Luke Fazi Awards
Left to right: Tim Burleson, Athletic Director, presents awards to Parker Guthery, and Sarah Woods



William Calvert Dedication Award
Daniel Guthery and Parker Guthery



Benedictine Medal of Merit and Christian Service Award
Br. Dominic Lee, Luke Daly, Sarah Woods, Phoung Nguyen, and Fr. Joel Martin.

Middle School Awards



Middle School Academic Awards
Murphy Thomas and Jesús Sanchez Andrade



Middle School Christian Leadership Awards
Murphy Thomas and Azlynn Florence

St. Bernard Happenings

2026 Senior Profiles

Anna Agnello: *Faith, Family, and Finding Purpose*



For **Anna Agnello**, St. Bernard Preparatory School has never just been a place to learn—it has been a place to grow, to belong, and to deepen her faith. As the third of seven sisters to graduate from St. Bernard, with two more still to follow, **Anna's** journey is woven into both her family's story and the life of the school itself.

Reflecting on her time at St. Bernard, **Anna** speaks most fondly of the relationships she has built and the foundation of faith that has guided her. "I enjoyed having such a Christ-centered education," she shares, "and I absolutely loved meeting so many people and building new relationships."

That sense of connection has been especially meaningful in the mentorship she found along the way. **Anna** credits Mr. Griffin as a steady and compassionate influence in her life. "He has been a role model, offering both spiritual and fatherly advice since my dad passed when I was really little," she says. She also found inspiration in Mr. Matthew Shaddrix, whose passion for faith and the arts made a lasting impression. "He's so Christ-centered, and we've had such fun conversations about theater and music."

At the heart of **Anna's** story is her family. "My mom is my greatest role model," she says. "She's amazing—raising seven girls. We are a house full of best friends." That bond has shaped Anna's outlook on life, grounding her in love, resilience, and gratitude.

Anna's interests reflect both her creativity and her curiosity. She found joy on stage and in song, cherishing her time in the choir and her role in the production of *And Then There Were None*. In the classroom, she discovered a love for literature, especially the works of Jane Austen, William Shakespeare, and the Brontë sisters. "I love British literature," she says.

Outside of school, **Anna** treasures the moments she can spend traveling with her family. Though busy schedules often make it difficult, their trips to Texas, North Carolina, and especially the Florida coast are memories she holds close. "I love the beach, especially Miramar Beach," she says. "It's a family-friendly place that has fun aspects for teenagers and young adults."

Through it all, **Anna** says St. Bernard has shaped her in profound ways. "It taught me to detach my will and to surrender to God's will better than before," she explains. "Also, how to accept the pains that come from struggles, but to trust that when things don't go as planned, it's because God has a better plan."

As she looks back, **Anna** also offers a thoughtful perspective on how the school community can grow stronger. She hopes to see more connections between younger and older students. "There's too much of a divide between upper and lower classmen," she notes. "We need to bring back the mentor program." It's a reflection of her desire to ensure others experience the same sense of belonging she has found.

This fall, **Anna** will attend the University of Alabama, where she plans to continue exploring her interests as she decides on a major. Wherever her path leads, she carries with her a strong faith, a deep love for her family, and the lessons learned from a community that helped shape who she is today.

Anna is the daughter of Emily Agnello of Cullman.

St. Bernard Prep Senior **Luke Baney** *plans to become a firefighter*



For **Luke Baney**, the past two years have been defined by meaningful friendships, personal growth, and learning to navigate both joy and hardship with strength.

"I've really enjoyed my time here, especially the friends I've made here at St. Bernard," **Luke** said. "That's been the best part of St. Bernard."

Luke speaks highly of the teachers who have influenced him, especially Mr. Shaddrix. "I like how strong he is in his faith and his opinions," he shared. "We can talk about controversial topics, but also just have fun conversations like Dungeons & Dragons. Last year, he even gifted me a Dungeons & Dragons book, which was really awesome."

Faith and perseverance are themes that run deep in **Luke's** life, inspired largely by his father. "My dad owns his own therapy practice and works long hours," **Luke** said. "He's extremely creative and very strong in his faith. That's something I want for myself, too."

One of **Luke's** proudest accomplishments at St. Bernard was completing his Eagle Scout project, building a Wayside Shrine in front of Swisher Hall. The project took on even greater meaning as he worked through a difficult personal loss. "Losing my girlfriend, Sarah Cumbie, has been a struggle," Luke shared honestly. "But I'm doing better, and my school family has been very supportive through it all."

Luke found success in archery, a sport he took up during his time at St. Bernard. "Archery was a lot of fun," he said. "I got pretty good with a compound bow, and making it to state was a big moment. We were close to nationals, and I shot my highest score there, so it was a really good day."

Beyond the classroom and competitions, **Luke** has been actively involved in volunteering at school festivals and participating in service club activities. His commitment to helping others will continue after graduation.

"I plan to attend the Huntsville Fire Academy to become a firefighter and EMT," Luke said. "I grew up in California, and every few years, wildfires would sweep through. Watching firefighters respond to those situations really stuck with me. I want to be able to serve the community."

Luke's life experiences have been anything but ordinary. "I've been struck by lightning, had a bomb squad called because I left my backpack in a church, fallen off a cliff, climbed mountains, and road-tripped from California to Alabama multiple times," he said with a smile.

When he's not busy, Luke enjoys spending time outdoors with friends. "We like to go hiking or just hang out at parks," he said. "And at home, I like relaxing with my cat, Tiger—he usually ends up sleeping on my chest."

As graduation approaches, **Luke** reflects on what he will carry with him. "St. Bernard has given me a strong support system," he said. "That's something I'll always be grateful for."

Tomboy Spirit and Sharp Aim: Senior **Rachel Bennett** *Blazes Her Own Trail to Graduation*



There's a certain kind of legend that doesn't announce itself with trophies or headlines—it shows up in muddy boots, a crooked grin, and just enough mischief to keep life interesting. At St. Bernard Preparatory School, that legend might just be **Rachel Bennett**.

Rachel, the youngest of three Bennetts to make it across the graduation stage, has spent the last six years carving out her own story after transferring from Sacred Heart. Being the "baby" of the family didn't mean she stayed in the background—far from it. She just did things her own way.

"I have always been in Catholic school, and am ready to be done with it," **Rachel** laughed, flashing that easy smile. "I've never really liked school, but I'm glad it's done."

And yet, somehow, she made it memorable.

If you picture **Rachel**, you might first notice her—long, luscious dark brown hair, a natural beauty—but stick around a minute, and you'll realize she's far more likely to be talking about duck blinds than hairstyles. A tomboy through and through, Rachel would trade a dress for camo any day of the week.

Give her a quiet morning, a stretch of water, and she's happy. Even better if there's a shotgun or fishing rod in hand.

"I have better aim with a shotgun than most men," she grinned, not even trying to hide her confidence.

She's not kidding. **Rachel** hunts with a 20-gauge Retay and knows her way around the water with an Abu Garcia bait caster, usually casting swim or glide baits in pursuit of the biggest bass she can find. Duck hunting, though—that's the real favorite.

"I personally don't like to eat duck, but my brother does," she added with a shrug, like that explained everything—which, for **Rachel**, it kind of does.

Her love for the outdoors started early. Really early.

"From the time I was five, I would tag along with my dad and brother," she said. "I had my moments when I was a little brat, but they took me anyway."

Those days stuck. So did the influence of her family—especially her dad.

"My dad has been the greatest role model in my life," **Rachel** said. "He had what he needed growing up, but is now a successful business owner."

At school, **Rachel** might tell you she "just made her way through," but along the way, she found people who mattered. One of them was Mr. Matthew Shaddrix.

"Mr. Shaddrix is someone I feel like I could tell anything to," she said.

And then there were her friends—her "giggle buddies," as she calls them—the kind of friendships that turn ordinary days into something worth remembering.

"The best thing I learned is the value of a good friendship," **Rachel** said. "I just made my way through."

When she wasn't with friends or outdoors, **Rachel** could usually be found with her loyal sidekick, Tucker, her goofy boxer bulldog.

"He's always happy to see me," she said. "Wagging his tail when I get home."

Ask **Rachel** what she's proudest of, and she won't overthink it.

"Graduating," she said simply.

It's the kind of answer that fits her perfectly—honest, straightforward, no extra fluff.

Next up, **Rachel** is heading into the world of commercial electricity, working this summer with Impact Electric in Birmingham. It's a path that suits her—hands-on, a little unpredictable, and not without its edge.

"I'm still figuring out what I want to do," she admitted. "Even though electricity is dangerous, I kinda like the risk."

Of course she does.

If **Rachel** could go back and change anything, she'd keep it simple, just like everything else in her life.

"Worry about the big things," she said. "This too shall pass."

That might be the best way to understand **Rachel Bennett**: not someone trying to fit into a mold, but someone who quietly—and sometimes loudly—makes her own. An open book, a little wild, fiercely loyal, and entirely herself.

"I'm pretty much an open book," she said.

And what a story it's been...



From Gym Floors to New Shores: Senior **Kaitlyn Chamblee** *Dribbles Toward a Bright Future*

For senior **Kaitlyn Chamblee**, the path to graduation has been anything but accidental—it's been a journey shaped by faith, family, and a lifelong commitment to Catholic education.

"From the time when I was three years old, a family friend worked as the 3K teacher at Sacred Heart and encouraged my mother to send me there," **Kaitlyn** shared. "Due to this, I followed the path from Sacred Heart to St. Bernard."

That path led her to more than just classrooms—it led her to the court, where many of her most meaningful memories were made. "While at St. Bernard I have enjoyed sports the most, especially basketball. I have been introduced to some of my favorite people through sports and have also learned more lessons than I can count. Some of my most cherished memories have been made in the gym."

A standout athlete, **Kaitlyn** earned All-Area basketball honors and served as President of the Senior Class—two accomplishments that reflect both her leadership and determination.

Off the court, **Kaitlyn's** inspiration comes from those closest to her. She credits her mother, Pat Ivey of Hanceville, as her greatest role model. "My mother has always provided me with the best, even if it meant sacrificing her own needs. She has never given up, even after the death of my father. I can honestly say that she is my best friend!"

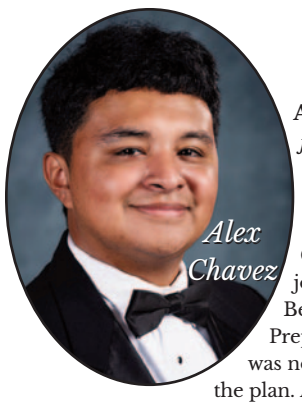
At school, one mentor in particular left a lasting impression. "Mr. Matthew Shaddrix has shown me that there is more to life than grades. In the end, what matters most is how we served God. He is a good listener and gives advice when we need it."

When she's not studying or competing, **Kaitlyn** enjoys baking, painting, and spending time babysitting her three-year-old niece.

After graduation, **Kaitlyn** will head south to attend the University of South Alabama, where she plans to major in Exercise Science. "I made this choice in hopes of studying physical therapy after I receive my undergraduate degree," she said. "This major will give me an understanding of the human body and its functions that will help me prepare for my doctorate."

While excited about academics, **Kaitlyn** is equally enthusiastic about the adventure ahead. "I'm looking forward to starting fresh somewhere I have never been. It will be unique to me, as I don't have any family there. I am excited for the opportunities it will bring—and I'm definitely looking forward to beach life."

Reflecting on her high school experience, **Kaitlyn** offers thoughtful advice to younger students. "I wish I had been a bit more outgoing while at St. Bernard. Take advantage of all the opportunities offered. I have now realized that people will judge you no matter what, but the only opinion that matters is Jesus, so don't let what others may think about you dictate your life. Go for it!"



Alex Chavez *finds leadership and faith at St. Bernard Prep*

For **Alex Chavez**, the journey to St. Bernard Preparatory School was not always part of the plan. After attending Cullman High School during his freshman year, **Alex** admits he never imagined himself wearing a school uniform every day or attending a Catholic school full-time. Looking back now, however, he says the decision changed his life for the better.

"I don't regret it at all," **Alex** shared. "I'm glad for the opportunity. I have grown into a better person."

The oldest of three children, **Alex** comes from a close-knit family rooted in faith and education. His younger sister currently attends St. Bernard, while his brother attends Sacred Heart. **Alex** credits much of his path to the guidance of his father, Luis Chavez, who encouraged the family to pursue Catholic education.

"My father suggested that our family further our education in Catholic schools, so I came to St. Bernard," he explained.

Over the past several years, **Alex** has become a familiar and respected face on campus — known for his outgoing personality, leadership, and steady determination. Whether in the classroom, on the soccer field, or serving the Church, he has embraced almost every aspect of student life.

Alex pushed himself academically through a demanding schedule that included AP U.S. History, AP Literature, and AP Government. Beyond the classroom, he dedicated himself to athletics as a three-year member of the soccer team and a cross-country runner during his sophomore year. Known for his steady leadership and positive attitude, **Alex** earned the respect of his teammates and was selected as co-captain of the soccer team.

Yet among his many accomplishments, **Alex** considers one role especially meaningful: serving as second in command of the Knights of the Altar. His faith journey became one of the most transformative parts of his time at St. Bernard.

He credits Religion teacher Matthew Shaddrix with helping shape that spiritual growth.

"Mr. Shaddrix helped me find God again and made me a brand new person in my faith," **Alex** said.

Another powerful influence in **Alex's** life has been his mother, Lucero Michaus, whom he calls his greatest role model.

"She has taught me to persevere even with my back against the wall," he shared.

Friends have also played an important role in his development. **Alex** credits former student Joey Shadowens (PS' 25) with helping him develop the discipline and confidence to become a stronger independent learner.

When he is not busy with school or activities, **Alex** enjoys spending time outdoors running and appreciating nature, working out at the gym, reading, and playing video games. One of his favorite ways to relax is spending time with the family's husky, Frosty.

Alex describes himself as social and outgoing, someone who tends to approach situations logically while still caring deeply about the people around him. That balance of confidence and compassion has made him a respected student leader among his peers.

As he prepares for graduation, **Alex** plans to begin his college education at Wallace State Community College before transferring to The University of Alabama to study finance.

Even as he celebrates his experiences at St. Bernard, **Alex** hopes future students will continue working to make the school feel welcoming and accepting to every newcomer walking through its doors.

His advice to incoming students reflects the resilience he has developed throughout his journey:

"Stay calm. Keep pushing forward. Setbacks are natural. Keep your head up and keep moving forward."



Luke Daly: *SBP Senior of Service and Faith*

For senior **Luke Daly**, St. Bernard Preparatory School became much more than a school — it became home.

Five years ago, **Luke's** family moved from Maryland to Cullman in search of something deeper than academics. They wanted a place where faith was not pushed aside, but embraced daily.

"We were looking for a place that supported the values we believed in and would help me grow," **Luke** shared.

After attending public school in Maryland, **Luke** entered St. Bernard in the eighth grade. As the second of three Daly brothers to attend the school, he quickly discovered there was something different about life there.

"St. Bernard seemed to be different," he said. "It was a lot smaller, people were friendly, and I felt at home. It was nice to be able to talk about God and see a crucifix on the wall. I was allowed to participate in as many sports as I wanted."

Those who know **Luke** describe him as one of the kindest and most genuine young men on campus — someone whose quiet humility and servant's heart reflect the Benedictine spirit that defines St. Bernard.

Luke especially treasures the relationships he formed with the monks during his years at the school. Whether serving behind the scenes or helping wherever needed, he embraced every opportunity to give back to the community.

"I have worked in the kitchen, the grotto, helped the monks clean out the monastery, harvested wheat, helped Fr. Bede with chickens, and worked with Br. Joseph in the carpenter shop," **Luke** said. "My brothers and I have also raked leaves in the fall to help the monks in any way possible."

Service quickly became woven into the fabric of **Luke's** life at St. Bernard. His quiet dedication and willingness to help others earned him numerous honors, including being elected Grand Supreme Knight of the Knights of the Altar and receiving the prestigious Benedictine Medal of Merit Award. He faithfully served as an altar server, took an active leadership role in the Service Club, where he especially enjoyed participating in the Bye-Bye Bags project for soldiers preparing to deploy from Fort Campbell.

Alongside his many service commitments, **Luke** also spent five years as a devoted member of the cross-country team.

Despite his many accomplishments, **Luke** remains refreshingly grounded. Outside of school, he works part-time in the meat department at Walmart while planning carefully for his future.

After graduation, **Luke** hopes to continue his education through Walmart's training program in electrical work or HVAC, though he is also considering Wallace State's electrical program.

A little-known fact about **Luke** is that in his free time, he enjoys helping his father at home, running at the park, and even building LEGO sets — especially Star Wars collections.

"I still love LEGOs," **Luke** laughed. "We used to build LEGO sets all the time, and we still get them sometimes."

Luke credits much of his spiritual foundation to his grandmother, Jane Daly, whose faith deeply influenced his own.

"She has always believed in me while in school," he said. "She helped me love my faith, pray the rosary, and I enjoyed going to Mass with her. She has always been such a light in my life and a wonderful person to be around."

Another major influence in **Luke's** life has been religion teacher Mr. Shaddrix.

"Mr. Shaddrix has taught me so much about the faith," Luke shared. "He is very inspiring and generous. He has supported our class even when he has gone through hard times himself. He has had such a fascinating life — being a lawyer, teacher, and theater director."

Over the years, **Luke** says St. Bernard helped shape him into a stronger, more confident young man.

"Being at St. Bernard has taught me how to better communicate with people, to share how I feel, and to confront uncomfortable truths," he said.

As he reflects on his years at the school, Luke also hopes future students will experience some of the traditions he admired from afar.

"I would love to see the House Program brought back to St. Bernard," he said. "I never got to experience it myself, but it looked like a lot of fun and kind of reminded me of Harry Potter."

For younger students beginning their own St. Bernard journey, **Luke** offers simple but heartfelt advice:

"It may be stressful in the beginning, but stay close to your faith. You will be okay."

Luke is the son of Richard and Shawnette Daly, and while his time at St. Bernard is drawing to a close, the example he leaves behind — one of humility, faith, service, and kindness — will remain part of the school community for years to come.



From Altar Server to Anime Fan: **Ben Gil** *Makes the Most of Life at St. Bernard*

For senior **Ben Gil**, St. Bernard has always felt a little like home. With five siblings attending the school over the years, the Gil family name is practically woven into the fabric of campus life.

Now preparing to graduate, **Ben** leaves behind a legacy of friendship, faith, humor, and plenty of unforgettable moments.

"I've really enjoyed the sports, the religious side of the school, and especially the friendships," **Ben** said.

This fall, **Ben** plans to attend Troy University to study finance, a field he believes offers endless possibilities.

"I'm still unsure exactly what I want to do in the future," he admitted. "But finance gives me great opportunities."

And if life goes according to plan, those opportunities may take him far beyond Alabama.

"I definitely want to travel a lot," Ben said. "Hopefully Germany someday."

While Ben enjoys looking ahead, he credits several teachers at St. Bernard for helping shape who he has become today.

"Mrs. Whaley really influenced me academically, especially in math," he explained. "She made me more determined and helped me take school seriously my freshman year."

He also credits religion teacher Matthew Shaddrix with helping him grow spiritually.

"I considered myself kind of a lukewarm Catholic before," Ben said. "Mr. Shaddrix helped me take my faith more seriously."

One of **Ben's** favorite parts of St. Bernard has been participating in the annual *March for Life* trips, experiences he says had a lasting impact on him. He also enjoyed the senior retreat and the weekly reflection papers in religion class.

"Mr. Shaddrix lets us tie morality into our writing, and that's always really interesting," he said.

Ben's biggest role models, however, are much closer to home — his older brothers.

"Fulton set the bar for how much we can accomplish in life," **Ben** said. "Charles and Nicholas have taught me how to have fun and enjoy life no matter what's happening."

Outside the classroom, **Ben's** interests are as colorful and unique as his personality. He enjoys drawing and doodling, gaming with friends, anime, and one particularly entertaining hobby: thrift shopping for fun clothes.

"I like finding funny shirts with stupid stuff on them," he laughed.

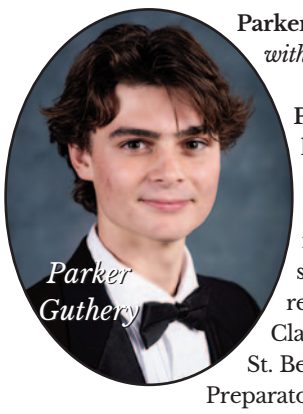
Ben also enjoys sampling matcha tea, though when it comes down to it, he admits, "it's Starbucks for the win."

As graduation approaches, **Ben** says there are many things he will miss about St. Bernard — especially altar serving, his close friendships, and surprisingly, the cafeteria.

"The food here is actually really good," he said. "I'm definitely going to miss the tres leches cake and the bang bang chicken."

Before college begins, **Ben** plans to enjoy a relaxing summer filled with work, a beach trip, and preparation for the next chapter of life.

Ben is the son of Francis Gil and Ting Yu.



Parker Guthery *signs with Lee University*

For six years, **Parker Guthery** has quietly built one of the most impressive student resumes in the Class of 2026 at St. Bernard Preparatory School. Soft-spoken and humble by nature, **Parker** may not be the loudest student in the room, but his accomplishments, work ethic, and character have made him one of the most respected seniors on campus.

As the son of Chanda Dabbs, St. Bernard's Guidance Counselor and Cross Country Coach, and Daniel Guthery, **Parker** was raised in the heart of the close-knit St. Bernard community. Following in the footsteps of his siblings, he now carries on the family tradition as the final Guthery to attend St. Bernard Prep.

During his time at St. Bernard, **Parker** challenged himself academically with a demanding schedule that included AP English, AP Government, BC Calculus, and Physics C. His sharp intellect and steady determination placed him among the top students in his class.

This fall, **Parker** will continue a cherished family tradition by attending Lee University, where his siblings also pursued their studies. There, he plans to compete in cross country for the Flames while exploring a future in the medical field.

"I'm not completely sure what I want to major in yet," **Parker** shared, "but I know I want to pursue medicine after college."

While **Parker** excels academically, athletics have also played a major role in shaping his St. Bernard experience. Over the years, he played basketball for one year, bowled for two years, and ran cross country and track and field for six years. His dedication to distance running earned him All-State honors in Cross Country, one of his proudest accomplishments as a student-athlete.

Recently, **Parker** was recognized with two of the school's most prestigious athletic honors. He received the Coach William Calvert Award, presented in honor of Coach William Calvert for his dedication to the sport of running and the countless lives impacted through his leadership. **Parker** was also awarded the Fr. Luke Fazi Award, the highest athletic honor presented at St. Bernard Preparatory School.

Despite the accolades, **Parker** remains remarkably grounded. He credits much of his growth to the influence of teacher Mr. Griffin.

"Mr. Griffin had the greatest impact on me while I was at St. Bernard," **Parker** said. "He always gives good advice."

Parker also admires Pope Leo I as his greatest role model because "he defended Rome with his words."

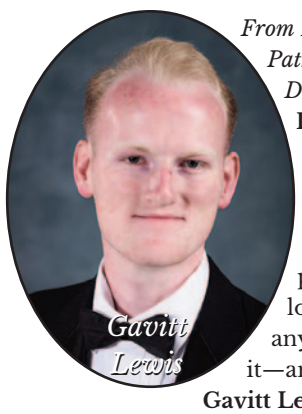
Outside of school, **Parker** enjoys spending time with friends by running and fishing. Fishing, he says, serves as his escape and a way to unwind from the demands of academics and athletics.

And while many classmates know him as a standout runner and exceptional student, **Parker** revealed one surprising fact few people know about him: he once dreamed of becoming a professional bowler.

Looking back on his six years at St. Bernard, **Parker** says there is very little he would change.

"I wouldn't change a thing," he said simply.

That quiet sense of gratitude and humility may ultimately define **Parker Guthery** best. Whether in the classroom, on the course, or among friends, he has consistently led by example by showing up every day.



From Predestined Paths to Big Dreams: **Gavitt Lewis** *Chases Goals On and Off the Field*

Some stories feel planned out long before anyone realizes it—and for senior **Gavitt Lewis**, that story started with family footsteps leading straight to St. Bernard.

Following in the path of both his sister and uncle, **Gavitt** admits his journey to campus was less of a question and more of a certainty. "It was kind of predestined that I would come here," he said, recalling his transfer from Sacred Heart. What he found was more than tradition—it was a place where competition, camaraderie, and a few unforgettable moments would shape his high school years.

Ask **Gavitt** what defined his time, and he won't point to just one highlight. Instead, it's the full ride of athletics—the wins, the losses, and everything in between. Being part of multiple sports teams gave him a sense of belonging and resilience. From scoring his first varsity basketball points to netting his first goal in varsity soccer, each milestone added to a growing list of memories. Still, one thing is clear: "I love all things soccer," **Gavitt** said, a statement backed up by his excitement recalling a trip to Atlanta to watch Chelsea take on LAFC—where his favorite player, Cole Palmer, took the field.

Off the field, **Gavitt's** talents stretch into the classroom. A member of the National Honor Society, Mu Alpha Theta, and the National English Honor Society, he has a clear passion for numbers. "I love anything numbers," he shared. That passion is guiding his next chapter as he heads to the University of Wyoming, following his mom's legacy, to major in finance with a minor in business. His ultimate goal? Blending his love of sports and analytics into a career in soccer finance—and maybe even taking that dream overseas. "I hope to end up in England to work," he said, already planning to study abroad.

Along the way, **Gavitt** has leaned on people who've made a lasting impact. When it comes to teachers, one name comes up without hesitation. "Mr. Shaddrix always has a positive attitude and brings a smile to my face. He has also given me countless numbers of good advice." And when it comes to role models, his admiration runs even deeper. His grandmother, Gretchen Gavitt, stands at the top of the list. "When she was younger, she was a great athlete, and she has always been the best grandmother encouraging me to do my best."

Beyond academics and athletics, **Gavitt** has quietly given back through volunteer work with Curt's Closet and school festivals.

And then there's one fun fact that's hard to top: as a child, **Gavitt** was once held by Sir Charles Barkley. Not a bad claim to fame for someone already building a story of his own.

Whether he's chasing a ball down the field, breaking down numbers, or dreaming about a future across the Atlantic, **Gavitt Lewis** is proof that sometimes destiny gives you a starting point—but it's what you do from there that really makes the story worth telling.

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Faith, Friendship, and Finding Purpose: **Josh Marks** *Reflects on His St. Bernard Journey*

For senior **Josh Marks**, the journey to St. Bernard Preparatory School began in seventh grade when he arrived from Cleveland Elementary School in Blount County. What first caught his attention was the beauty of the campus itself.

"St. Bernard is really nice," Josh said. "The buildings and the campus attracted me right away."

Over the years, however, it became much more than the scenery. **Josh** found a community that shaped both his education and his faith.

"The best parts were the teachers, friends, and going to Mass," he said.

One of the most meaningful moments of **Josh's** time at St. Bernard came last year when he converted to Catholicism and was baptized into the Catholic faith. He credits religion teacher Mr. Matthew Shaddrix for helping spark his interest.

"Mr. Shaddrix made religion interesting," **Josh** explained. "Going to Mass and watching YouTube videos made me more interested in the Catholic faith, so I took the steps at school and was baptized Catholic last year."

His sponsor was Jiovany Aguilar, a St. Bernard alumnus from the Class of 2023.

Josh says several faculty and mentors made a lasting impact on him during his years at the school.

"I have a lot of role models at St. Bernard," he said. "Fr. Joel, Mr. Shaddrix, Mrs. Dabbs, Br. Leo, Ms. Whaley, and Fr. Dominic have all been outstanding."

In addition to academics and campus life, Josh was active in Cross Country, where some of his most memorable experiences took place on the school's wooded trails.

"My greatest memory of St. Bernard took place on the trails," he laughed. "I set personal records in every race in Cross Country. I must admit I was ready for it to be over. It requires a lot of effort."

While he may continue running recreationally to stay in shape, **Josh** says his competitive racing days are behind him.

The arts also became an important outlet during his high school years. His favorite subject was art, where he especially enjoyed drawing with Mrs. Watts. He also appeared in the school production of *And Then There Were None*, portraying Anthony Marston.

"I was a spoiled rich kid," **Josh** joked, "but I was also the first to die."

Among his favorite senior memories was the Senior Retreat, which left a lasting emotional impact.

"It was fun and emotional," he said. "During the retreat, we wrote nice things about everyone, which was really cool. Seeing what classmates wrote definitely helped my ego a bit."

Outside of school, **Josh** enjoys spending time with his family cat, Socks, a black cat with white paws.

"He's a grumpy old cat," **Josh** said, "but he's still really cute."

This fall, **Josh** received a Presidential Scholarship to University of Alabama and the Cullman Electric Cooperative Scholarship. Though undecided on a career path, he is considering studying law.

As he prepares to graduate, **Josh** encourages younger students to embrace the spiritual opportunities available at St. Bernard.

"Enjoy going to Mass and pay attention in religion classes," he advised. "Because the most important thing in life is being holy and reverent."

Kimberly McCormick *Celebrates Four-Year Journey at St. Bernard Preparatory School*



St. Bernard Prep School proudly recognizes graduating senior **Kimberly McCormick** of Attalla, Alabama, whose four-year experience as a boarding student reflects both personal growth and academic achievement.

The youngest of three children, **Kimberly** came to St. Bernard at the encouragement of her parents and quickly found her place within the school's close-knit community. Reflecting on her journey, she encourages new students to step outside their comfort zones. "Try to be friends with everyone," she advises. "Introduce yourself. I stayed in my own little circle at first and wish I had been more outgoing."

Academically, **Kimberly** challenged herself with a rigorous course load that included three Advanced Placement classes in Literature, Biology, and Government. Her hard work earned her acceptance to five colleges. She has chosen to attend the University of Alabama at Birmingham on a Provost Scholarship. While she is still exploring her specific path, she is considering a future in the medical field.

During her time at St. Bernard, **Kimberly** found inspiration in the classroom, particularly through the guidance of Mr. Matthew Shaddrix and Fr. Dominic. "They have both shown kindness to other students and me," she shared. "Because of them, I understand math and religion better."

Kimberly's accomplishments extend beyond academics. She was inducted into the National Honor Society, served as a flyer on the cheerleading squad, and earned an *Excellence in Precalculus Award.* She also demonstrated a strong commitment to service by volunteering at the Bloomin' Festival and Bernard Blues, assisting in the food tent and parking operations.

Grounded by the example of her family, whom she describes as her greatest role models, **Kimberly** values time spent together—whether going to the mall, watching movies, or enjoying board games like Monopoly. In her free time, she also enjoys baking, especially chocolate chip cookies and the occasional oatmeal treat.

As **Kimberly** prepares to graduate, she leaves behind a legacy of quiet determination, kindness, and growth.

Kimberly is the daughter of Robert McCormick and Nancy Guerrero of Attalla, AL.



Hooked on Heart: **Emma Osborne's** *Journey from Court Wins to Caring Future*

There's a certain kind of student every school hopes to have—someone who can celebrate a big win on the court, laugh through lunch table conversations, and still find joy casting a fishing line into quiet water. At St. Bernard, that student is **Emma Osborne**.

Emma's six-year journey began with a leap of faith—from Sacred Heart to a new campus, new faces, and new routines. "It was a smooth transition," she says, crediting the welcoming community for making it feel like home almost instantly. That sense of belonging is exactly why she encourages others to follow her path. "The teachers are amazing, and the people create such a positive atmosphere."

If you ask **Emma** where she's grown the most, she won't hesitate: patience. It's a skill she's developed over time—whether working through a tough assignment or waiting for the perfect moment to reel in a fish. And yes, fishing is one of her favorite ways to unwind. "Catch and release," she explains with a grin, usually with a spinning lure—and often alongside her close friend Rachel Bennett. Her adventurous side even led her to try dove hunting once. "I didn't shoot—I was just there for the experience," she laughs. "But I'd do it again. Now I know what to expect!"

Inside the classroom, one teacher made a lasting impression. "Fr. Dominic has helped me understand math in a way no one else could," **Emma** shares. "I'm grateful because math makes so much more sense to me now. He has a great personality and is a funny person." It's that blend of encouragement and humor that sticks with her.

But some of **Emma's** favorite memories happened off the page—especially on the basketball court. She still lights up talking about last year's area tournament. "It's rare for St. Bernard to win in 20 years," she says. "I remember being nervous the whole game, and then we won. It was so joyful—we wanted to cry because we were so happy as a team." And then came the moment every player dreams of: "Cutting the net off the rim was very exciting."

When she's not studying or playing sports, **Emma** gives back to her community. From helping at school festivals to serving drinks at her grandfather Fred Osborne's fish fry with the Lions Club, she's always ready to lend a hand. That spirit of service is rooted in family—especially her greatest role model. "My mom is my biggest supporter," **Emma** says, smiling with pride. "Her work ethic is strong, and I hope to have that trait."

And then there's Sadie, her 14-year-old Yorkie, who may not see, hear, or have more than three teeth—but still has plenty of fight left. "We got her for Christmas when I was three or four," Emma says. "She's still kicking."

Looking ahead, **Emma** plans to attend the University of North Alabama to pursue a degree in nursing. Her motivation comes from a deeply personal place. "When I was younger, I was really sick and spent a lot of time in the hospital," she explains. "I want to give back the love the nurses gave me."

Before she goes, **Emma** has one hope for the place that's given her so much: "I'd love to see more students get involved—especially in things like bowling, tennis, and maybe even golf."

Whether she's cheering on her team, helping her community, or preparing for a future in healthcare, **Emma Osborne** brings heart, humor, and a quiet determination to everything she does. And if you ever need a fishing partner—or someone to remind you that patience pays off—she's your girl.

Emma is the daughter of Fred and Laurie Osborne of Cullman.



"St. Bernard or Bust": **Daniel Pichardo's** *Six-Year Journey Leads to a Global Dream*

For **senior Daniel Pichardo**, the path to St. Bernard Preparatory School was never in question—it was simply "St. Bernard or bust." After spending his entire early education at Sacred Heart, Daniel arrived on campus six years ago and quickly found more than just a school—he found a community.

"We have a tight-knit community," **Daniel** shared. "It's a place where people really support each other."

That sense of belonging helped shape a student who would go on to challenge himself in remarkable ways. **Daniel** applied to more than 45 colleges across the country, earning an impressive number of scholarship offers along the way. This fall, he will attend the University of South Alabama, drawn not only by generous scholarships but also by its coastal charm. "It's close to the beach and a very nice town," he said.

Daniel plans to major in mathematics and health informatics, with a long-term goal of entering the field of epidemiology. His aspirations reach far beyond the classroom—he hopes to one day work with the World Health Organization, using data and statistics to better understand and improve global health.

Ironically, **Daniel's** passion for math wasn't always a given.

"I always hated math and thought I wasn't good at it," he admitted. "I barely passed middle school math." That all changed in Mrs. Whaley's geometry class. "She changed the way I look at math. I actually started enjoying it and realized I liked it because I had a different perspective."

That theme—seeing things differently—has been a defining part of **Daniel's** St. Bernard experience.

He credits Fr. Dominic, his Algebra II teacher, as both a mentor and a role model. "He's a really great teacher and a good person. He gave me confidence," **Daniel** said.

In English, Mrs. Hasenbein reignited a spark he thought he had lost. "I lost my love for English because it felt boring, but her passion is contagious," he explained. "She taught me I don't have to be a perfectionist—that I can take things step by step and enjoy the process."

Outside the classroom, **Daniel** has been just as dedicated. A four-year member of the jazz band, he brought music to life on the baritone saxophone. He has also been a familiar and reliable presence at campus events, regularly volunteering his time at the Bloomin' Festival and Bernard Blues & BBQ.

Whether in academics, the arts, or service, **Daniel** has approached every opportunity with determination and humility.

"St. Bernard has taught me to look at things from many perspectives," he said.

It's a lesson that will serve him well as he heads toward a future defined not just by numbers and data—but by purpose, curiosity, and a desire to make a difference on a global scale.

Daniel is the son of Mariano and Migdalia Pichardo of Cullman.

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Charli Roberson *Makes the Most of Every Moment at St. Bernard*



For senior **Charli Roberson**, returning to St. Bernard was one of the easiest decisions she ever made.

After attending Sacred Heart and beginning high school at St. Bernard, **Charli** transferred to Cullman High School for a period of time. But it did not take long for her to realize something was missing.

"I missed it, so I came back," said **Charli**.

Now preparing to graduate, **Charli** says returning to St. Bernard allowed her to rediscover the close-knit atmosphere and meaningful relationships that made the school feel like home.

"One thing I especially loved was the one-on-one time with teachers," she said. "That personal connection really made a difference."

Among all of her high school memories, the Senior Retreat stands out as her favorite experience.

"It was so much fun reminiscing, and it was a very sentimental day," she recalled. "Our parents wrote us sweet letters, and we all cried a lot of tears."

The day-long retreat concluded with dinner at Freddy Day's alongside Mr. Matthew Shaddrix, Ms. Whaley, and Fr. Dominic — a perfect ending to one of the most emotional and memorable days of senior year.

Charli has also excelled academically during her time at St. Bernard. Ranked among the top students in her class, she is currently taking AP Calculus, AP Physics, AP Government, and AP Literature.

"The coursework at St. Bernard has increased my work ethic and made me more productive in other areas of life, not just academics," she said.

That determination has paid off in every area of her life. **Charli** earned All-Area honors in basketball and placed third in the state in the 100-meter hurdles.

After applying to several colleges, **Charli** accepted a full-ride opportunity to attend the University of Alabama, where she received both the Prestige Scholarship and a competitive housing scholarship. She plans to study pre-med with hopes of eventually attending medical school to become a dermatologist.

"When the full ride to Bama happened, I made my decision," she said.

Charli credits St. Bernard instructor Mr. Matthew Shaddrix as one of the most influential people in her life.

"Both of our lives have been impacted by cancer, and he has shown me it's all a part of God's plan," she shared.

Her greatest inspiration, however, is her mother, Christine Roberson.

"My parents have had such an impact on my life because they both run the family business," said **Charli**. "But my mom is the strongest woman I know."

Charli speaks openly and lovingly about her mother's ongoing battle with stage four cancer and the perseverance she demonstrates every day.

"She is such a woman of faith and faces her challenges with incredible courage," said **Charli**. "She is always looking out for our family, and I'm in awe that she keeps showing up for work every single day. That inspires me more than anything."

Outside the classroom, **Charli's** vibrant personality shines just as brightly through her special bond with her father and their shared love of cars.

Growing up, she never quite knew what vehicle her dad might arrive in when it was time for school pickup.

"In elementary school, we never knew what he was going to be driving," she laughed. "One day he came rolling up in a Winnebago."

Those moments sparked a lifelong appreciation for unique vehicles and plenty of laughter-filled memories together. **Charli** dreams of owning both a Mercedes G-Wagon and a Porsche.

"Just like my dad, I like bougie cars with personality," she joked.

The family's love for Tesla eventually became contagious.

"After I got mine, my dad, grandfather, friend, and cousin Lily all ended up getting Teslas too," she said.

Charli enjoys spending time outdoors with her friends Rachel, Ruth, Emily, and Lily whom she has known since kindergarten.

Outside of school, **Charli** enjoys pickleball, working out at the gym, tanning, skiing, tubing, and spending time at the lake.

"One might say I have a shopping addiction" **Charli** grinned.

As graduation approaches, **Charli** offers a few meaningful words of advice to incoming freshmen:

"The time flies by, so even though school has its challenges, make the most of it, because you will miss it."

Charli is the daughter of Micky and Christine Roberson of Cullman.



St. Bernard Preparatory School Senior **Mariella Tombo** *Sets Sights on Teaching Career*

St. Bernard Preparatory School proudly recognizes graduating senior **Mariella Tombo** of Birmingham, Alabama, a residential student whose journey has been shaped by faith, family, and a growing passion for serving others.

Mariella arrived at St. Bernard as a freshman, following in the footsteps of her three older siblings. Over the past four years, she has embraced both the academic and spiritual opportunities the school offers. Reflecting on her experience, she shares that some of her most meaningful moments have come through friendships and faith formation alongside classmates such as Kimberly McCormick and Ben Gil.

Her time at St. Bernard has also deepened her sense of purpose. "I've always had a love for children," **Mariella** says. "I've worked at Camp St. Bernard for three years in high school, and that really solidified my desire to work with kids." This passion has guided her decision to attend the University of Alabama at Birmingham, where she plans to major in elementary education and pursue a career as a teacher.

Mariella credits much of her growth to the influence of faculty members, especially Fr. Dominic and Mr. Shaddrix. "Both are really good teachers, and I always see them treating students with the same dignity and respect across the board," she notes.

Beyond the classroom, **Mariella** has been an active member of the St. Bernard community. She has volunteered regularly at school events, particularly helping with concessions, and has taken on leadership responsibilities as Head Proctor in the dormitory. Living in the residential community has been transformative, teaching her valuable lessons in patience, kindness, and understanding. "Seeing some of the students in the dorm, I have learned a lot about people, especially living with them," she reflects.

Mariella's interests extend into the arts and athletics. She enjoys running, dancing, and reading, with a particular love for ballet, tap, jazz, and hip-hop. Her musical tastes range from jazz artist Laufey to contemporary pop, depending on her mood.

Family has remained a constant source of encouragement throughout her journey. "My older siblings have guided me through my college application journey and inspired me even when the odds are not always in my favor," she says.

As she prepares for college, **Mariella** offers thoughtful advice to future students: "Put yourself out there. I wish I had participated in more sports. You don't know until you try what you are capable of."

With plans to work this summer before beginning college, **Mariella Tombo** leaves St. Bernard as a compassionate leader, a dedicated student, and a young woman ready to make a lasting impact in the lives of children.

Mariella is the daughter of Deanna Tombo of Birmingham, Alabama.

ST. BERNARD
PREPARATORY SCHOOL



Sarah Woods *Leaves a Lasting Legacy at St. Bernard Prep*

For **Sarah Woods** of Warrior, Alabama, graduation from St. Bernard Preparatory School marks more than the end of her senior year — it closes a remarkable chapter for an entire family legacy. As the youngest of four Woods children to attend St. Bernard, **Sarah** proudly carries on a tradition of faith, leadership, scholarship, and service that has become synonymous with the Woods name on campus.

A graduate of Sacred Heart School, where she attended from first through sixth grade, **Sarah** arrived at St. Bernard and immediately immersed herself in every aspect of school life. Over the years, she became one of the most accomplished and respected students in the senior class, earning admiration from classmates, teachers, and coaches alike.

What **Sarah** treasured most about her St. Bernard experience was the close-knit community.

"Being able to spend time with all of my friends," she said. "I love being able to see and talk to so many people from all the different grades."

Her impact on campus can hardly be overstated. **Sarah** graduates at the top of her class while completing one of the school's most rigorous academic schedules, including AP Physics, AP Calculus BC, AP Literature, AP Government, and AP Biology.

But her achievements did not stop in the classroom.

A true multi-sport athlete, **Sarah** competed in volleyball, basketball, soccer, track, bowling, and archery during her years at St. Bernard. Her dedication, leadership, and sportsmanship earned her the prestigious Fazi-Richard Athletic Award, the school's highest athletic honor. She also received the Christian Service Award, the highest non-academic honor bestowed by the school, for her commitment to serving others and living out the Benedictine values of St. Bernard.

Leadership has long come naturally to Sarah. She served as Student Government Association President, Class President for two years, National Honor Society President, National Junior Honor Society President, captain of the soccer team and basketball team, and was honored with the Basketball Leadership Award two consecutive years. She also brought her musical talents to campus, playing alto saxophone and contributing to the arts community at St. Bernard.

Despite an impressive resumé, **Sarah** remains grounded and approachable. Outside of school, she enjoys crafting, machine embroidery, designing vinyl T-shirts, drawing, and playing video games.

"My brother gave me his PC a while ago, and my dad and I play a bunch of games on it," **Sarah** shared with a smile. "Fallout 4 has to be my favorite."

This summer, **Sarah** plans to stay busy working at Camp St. Bernard and at Sonic in Warrior while spending as much time as possible with family and friends before leaving for college in August.

She will attend the University of Alabama on the Kenneth M. Carnathan Alumni Scholarship, where she plans to major in mechanical engineering and pursue her MBA.

"It's a lucrative career, and I have always loved building things and creating," she explained.

Sarah credits Jonathan Farley as one of the teachers who most influenced her during her years at St. Bernard.

"Mr. Farley had the greatest impact on me because he offered good advice on how to live life well and meaningfully," she said.

Still, **Sarah** says her greatest role models have always been her parents, Alan and Carrie Woods.

"Both my mom and dad have been amazing with raising me. I want to be like both of them when I'm older," she said.

When reflecting on her greatest accomplishments, **Sarah** does not point first to awards or titles.

"Making the friends that I have and spending time with them as well as enjoying my time here without stressing myself out too much," she said.

In classic **Sarah** fashion, she also offered one thoughtful suggestion for improving student life at St. Bernard.

"I would allow seniors and juniors to be exempt from school exams if they are taking the AP exam, provided they have good grades and attendance," she said. "Those taking AP exams should also be allowed to be out of uniform and exempt from the rest of the day's classes because preparing for and taking AP exams is very taxing and tiring."





SBP's Gardening Club

Students at St. Bernard Prep School in Cullman, recently planted annual zinnia seeds in peat cups as part of their mission to help beautify our campus.
Pictured from left to right: Luke Baney, James Gillis, Emilie Gutowski and Gabriel Kibler

Honor, Merit Roll

HIGH SCHOOL HONOR ROLL
Spring Semester 2026
Semester Average
95.0 and Above

Grade 12

Katie Chamblee
Parker Guthery
Gavitt Lewis
Kimberly McCormick
Josh Marks
Emma Osborne
Charli Roberson
Sarah Woods

Grade 11

Ruth Adams
Karly Arndt
Charlotte Boykin
Alexis Cron
Sean Daly
Vanesa Francisco
James Gillis
Emilie Gutowski
Rafi Guevara
Aiden Hays
Logan Kretzschmar
Caroline McBride
Sage McDowell
Sam Myers
Tessa Sanders
Lily Tillitski
Liseli Uriarte
Yufei Wang
Julia Yohe

Grade 10

Maria Agnello
Norah Bissot
Caterina Botta
Alexa Chavez
Ella Cron
Anastasia Hazard
Avery Hines
Merry Carmen-Pichardo
Anthony Ranelli
Jacob Tombo

Grade 9

Brooklynn Agnello
Payton Becker
Chloe Brewer
Aaron Cortes-Villegas
Silas Krische
Saleen Mata
Andrew Nguyen
Zikora Obiora-Akubue
Murielle Pittet
Caroline Sanders
Grayson Stewart

MERIT ROLL
Grade 12
Spring Semester 2026
Semester Average 90.0 to 94.9

Anna Agnello
Luke Baney
Alex Chavez
Benedict Gil
Daniel Pichardo
Ella Tombo

Grade 11

Karime Dagnino-Villegas
Kieran Gargan
Joy Lamote
Irene Turcios-Galvez

Grade 10

Elsie Aguilar-Contreras
Victoria Becerra
Josue Chavez
Zoe Cross
Analia Lajara
Johnathan McBride
Kimberly Pantoja
Mia Reznichenko
Matthew Sauers

Grade 9

Josie Lamote
Ingrid Ramirez Quintero
Madison Rice

MIDDLE SCHOOL HONOR ROLL
Spring Semester 2026
Semester Average
95.0 and Above

Grade 8

Kade Chamblee
Azlynn Florence
Eleanor Franklin
Vivian Gargan
Jesús Sanchez Andrade
Murphy Thomas

Grade 7

Ryan Keough
Lily Kerber
Helena Perkins

MIDDLE SCHOOL MERIT ROLL
Spring Semester 2026
Semester Average
90.0 to 94.9

Grade 8

Nataly Chavez
David Martinez
Rosalinda Silva

Grade 7

Anamari Alonzo Gonzalez
Kathleen Bissot
Krislyn Contreras
Wyatt Cron
Brady Thomas
Lily Beth Veigl



St. Bernard Prep Theatre Performs *And Then There Were None*

St. Bernard Prep Theatre performed *And The There Were None* on April 10th and 11th at the Byre. The play, adapted by Samuel French, from the best selling crime novel of all time by the great Agatha Christie, was a success and a wonderful follow up to last year's *Our Love Must Die* (an adaptation of *Romeo & Juliet* set in medieval Japan). This year's production, set on an island off the coast of Dover, England in 1973 and included wonderful period hair, costumes, makeup, and music.

The students performed the play utilizing both of the play's endings, with the "happy" ending on night one and the original ending (envisioned by the novel's author) on the second. The play also utilized different casts in order to accommodate the talent present in the current student-body. Many seniors participated in addition to the three lead actors of the play who were comprised of two juniors, Sean Daly and Joy Lamote, and freshman Brooklyn Agnello. Perhaps the show-stealer was senior Josh Marks, who despite being the first to meet his Maker in the production received one of the loudest crowd "pops" on both nights during the curtain call.

St. Bernard Prep Artists Earn Recognition in Conservation and Congressional Competitions

Students at St. Bernard Preparatory School continue to distinguish themselves through artistic excellence, earning recognition in both county and congressional art competitions this spring.

St. Bernard was recently honored to welcome Kathy Holmes to campus as she presented awards to four students recognized in the annual poster contest sponsored by the Cullman County Soil & Water Conservation District.

The contest theme was "Soil: Where It All Begins." The contest, open to local schools across Cullman County, encourages students to explore and illustrate the importance of soil and conservation

Among the St. Bernard winners were Azlynn Florence, who earned 2nd place in the 7th–9th grade division, and Caroline Sanders, who received 3rd place honors in the same division.

In the 10th–12th grade category, Yesi Aburto-Santiago placed 2nd, while Parker Guthery earned 3rd place recognition. Each student received a monetary award for their achievement.

The students' artwork will remain on display through May with the Cullman County Soil & Water Conservation District, showcasing both their artistic creativity and commitment to environmental awareness.

St. Bernard students also recently participated in the Robert Aderholt Fourth Congressional District Art Competition held at Wallace State Community College. The event featured more than 223 student submissions from across the district, making it the largest competition of its kind to date. Robert Aderholt served as Honorary Chairman.

Among the standout participants was sophomore Analia Lajara, who captured 1st Place in the computer-generated art category, one of nine competition divisions.

In addition to earning top honors, Lajara was awarded a scholarship to Wallace State Community College in recognition of her achievement and promising future in the arts.

St. Bernard art instructor Amber Watts praised her students for their dedication and creativity, noting that they continually impress her with their artistic talent and commitment to excellence.



Soil and Water Conservation

Pictured from left to right: Amber Watts, Instructor; Yesi Aburto-Santiago (11th); Caroline Sanders (9th); Kathy Holmes, Cullman County Soil & Water Conservation District Administrative Coordinator, Azlynn Florence (8th), and Parker Guthery (12th).



Congressional Art Contest Winner

Analia Lajara, Congressional Art Winner, along with Amber Watts, Instructor

10th Annual
Win $10,000
September 12-13, 2026
2026 Bernard
BLUES AND BBQ
www.bernardbluesbbq.com

Alumni Reunion 2026

The monks, faculty, and staff of St. Bernard Preparatory School warmly invite alumni and friends back to campus for the

2026 Alumni Reunion Weekend.

Reconnect with classmates, revisit cherished memories, and celebrate the enduring spirit of St. Bernard through a weekend filled with fellowship, prayer, laughter, and Benedictine hospitality.

Itinerary

Friday • June 26, 2026
Boniface Retreat Center
5:00 p.m. – Registration
5:30 p.m. – Dinner Alfresco

Saturday • June 27, 2026
Brahma Room
9:30 a.m. – Brunch
Campus Grounds
9:00 a.m. - 2:00 p.m. – Alumni Camp Day
Heidrich Library
2:30 p.m. - 4:00 p.m. –
Town Hall Meeting & Social Hour
Abbey Church
4:30 p.m. – Mass Byre
5:30 p.m. – Drinks & Social
6:15 p.m. – Reunion Dinner

Sunday • June 28, 2026
Dining Hall
8:00 a.m. – Breakfast

Cost

$125 – Full Weekend Package
$75 – Saturday Dinner Only
Register online:
stbernardprep.com/reunion or call Brandi Gibbs at (256)739-6682 to register.

Alumni Camp Day –

Separate registration through Johnny Arndt for young alumni 1986-2026 ($15 each or $25 per couple).

In Memory



Godfrey Weir Alexander

Mr. Godfrey Weir Alexander (C '66), 85, passed away peacefully on May 8, 2025, in Lake Wales, Florida. A graduate of St. Bernard High School in 1958 in Cullman, Alabama, Weir remained deeply committed to his Catholic faith, serving for many years as an usher at St. James Catholic Church in Orlando. Weir is survived by his wife of 49 years, Emily Pitts Alexander; his children, Godfrey Weir Alexander IV (Sharla), Elizabeth Lepic (Rich), Mary Susan Casselberry (Scott), Julia Whidden (Bill), Michelle Harris (Arell), Sarah Alexander, and Marianne Bishop (Bill); along with 15 grandchildren and 6 great-grandchildren. A Funeral Mass was held on May 21, 2025, at Saint James Catholic Cathedral in Orlando, with interment following at Woodlawn Memorial Park in Gotha.

William "Bill" Edward Bynum Jr. (C'72) of Horton, Alabama, passed away March 30, 2026, at his home. He was a graduate of Cullman High School, St. Bernard College, and the University of Alabama at Birmingham. Bill owned and operated the Bynum Family Restaurant and later worked as house parents and later as directors at Freedom Ranch Children's Home in Oneonta. He was devoted to his faith, and, alongside his late wife, Phyllis, cared for more than 70 children through their work at Freedom Ranch Children's Home. Bill is survived by sons: William E. Bynum III (Shayla) and Zachary Bynum (Sarah). Daughters: Angela Johnson (Phillip), Sherry Shelton (Michael), Brandy Huff (Jamie), and Amber Ingram (Brad); as well as 18 grandchildren and 18 great-grandchildren.

Donald Frank Hasenbein, (HS '54), passed away on April 19, 2026, at the age of 89. A lifelong resident of Cullman, he was a faithful member of Sacred Heart Catholic Church, attended St. Bernard College, and proudly served in the United States Marine Corps. Donald is survived by his devoted wife of 69 years, Catherine; his four daughters, Suzanne Hasenbein, Terri (Ricky) Christain, Beth Green, and Cindy Sexton; nine grandchildren; numerous great-grandchildren; and a host of extended family and friends.



Roman L. Chomskis

Roman L. Chomskis, 88, a former prep school soccer coach at St. Bernard, passed away January 23, 2026, surrounded by his family. A retired U.S. Army Command Sergeant Major, Roman served his country with distinction for more than 26 years, including during the Vietnam War, earning numerous commendations. He is survived by his beloved wife, Patricia; his children, Gerard (PS '05), Nicole (PS '08) (James) Fletcher, Lisa (Bryan) Zalner, Erick, Phil, and Ed (Amy) Torlina; along with twelve grandchildren and eight great-grandchildren.



Thor Metice Johansen III

Thor Metice Johansen III, (C'69) 88, of Savannah, Georgia, passed away peacefully at home on February 19, 2026, surrounded by his family. Born and raised in Savannah, he was the eldest son of Thor "Tee" and Theresa Johansen II. He attended Sacred Heart Catholic School, St. Bernard Boarding School in Cullman, Alabama, Armstrong Junior College—where he played basketball—and later the University of Georgia, graduating in 1963 with a degree in chemistry. Thor devoted 40 years to a distinguished career in the chemical industry, beginning with American Cyanamid and continuing through its transitions to Kemira and Kerr-McGee. He found great joy in golf, cheering on the Georgia Bulldogs, and, most of all, spending time with his family—especially his grandchildren. He is survived by his wife of 65 years, Esther, and their five children: Donna Johansen Stembridge (Milton), Mark Johansen, Craig Johansen (Amy Bess-Ochoa), Christy Johansen Wiggin, and Scott Johansen. He is also survived by his grandchildren, Emily Stembridge-Smith (Cameron), Thomas Wiggin, Ronni Ochoa, Ross Wiggin, and Penelope Johansen, along with several nieces, nephews, and extended family members.A memorial service was held at 2:00 p.m. on Thursday, February 26, 2026, at Fox & Weeks Islands Chapel on Whitmarsh Island.

Joseph Henry LaGrasso (C'69) of Detroit, Michigan died on April 8, 2026. After college at St. Bernard, he met his wife of 40 years, Cheri. As a leader in the produce industry, Joe spent more than 50 years building LaGrasso Brothers Produce into the large company it is today. Joe was a father to Stephanie (Philip) Trautman, Lindsay (Justin) Laskowski, and Alex LaGrasso; and four grandchildren. He was the brother of Michael LaGrasso and stepbrother of Jim Zerilli and Joe Zerilli.



Tova Beth Blackwood Lindsey

Tova Beth Blackwood Lindsey (PS '96) passed away on Saturday, April 18, 2026, at her residence. She was born August 30, 1978, to Tobby Vance Blackwood and Debbie Blackwood. She was preceded in death by her father, Tobby Vance Blackwood. Survivors include her son, Atticus (Raven) Lindsey; daughter, Athena Lindsey; granddaughter, Maelle Lindsey; sister, Tiffany (Christopher) Nash; niece, Jordan Nash; nephew, Colton Nash, and a host of family and friends. A Celebration of Life Service was held April 25 at Cullman Heritage Funeral Home in Cullman.

Rev. James "Jim" Kelly Mallett, 84, of Chattanooga, Tennessee, passed away March 21, 2026, at Alexian Rehabilitation and Healthcare of Signal Mountain. A retired Catholic priest of the Diocese of Nashville, he was ordained Dec. 17, 1966, at St. Peter's Basilica in Vatican City after studies at St. Bernard Seminary College and the Gregorian University in Rome, where he earned a doctorate in philosophical theology.

Rev. Mallett served in Memphis and Chattanooga, including as chaplain at the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga's Newman Club and Memorial Hospital, where he introduced an ecumenical chaplaincy program. He later held leadership roles in the Diocese of Nashville as chancellor, vicar general, and judicial vicar. He earned a master's degree from The Catholic University of America and a law degree from Vanderbilt University. Answering a call to parish ministry, he became pastor of Christ the King Catholic Church in Nashville, where he was deeply loved. In retirement, he taught at UTC, sharing his passion for human rights and international law.

He is survived by his sister, Patricia Ann Mallett Mayo; his aunt, Jean Campbell Glassco; and many cousins. A visitation was held April 1 . at Our Lady of Perpetual Help Catholic Church in Chattanooga, followed by the funeral Mass.



Joyce Watson

Joyce Watson, beloved wife, mother, grandmother, and dedicated professional, passed away peacefully on November 2, 2025, at the age of 81. Joyce was the devoted wife of Jamie Watson (C '65), with whom she shared 55 years of marriage. Together, they built a life in Atlanta, Georgia, where they raised their two sons, Will and Chris. She found immense joy in her role as "Grandma" to her cherished granddaughter and grandson. Joyce had a deep passion for helping others and spent 27 years serving as a Speech Pathologist at the Atlanta Speech School. A Celebration of Life Service was held on December 6, 2025, at FB Church, Roswell, Georgia with family and friends attending.



Eula Mae Wilson

Eula Mae Wilson (C '59) affectionately known by "Dood", age 97 of Addison, passed away on Wednesday, March 25, 2026, surrounded by her loving family. Eula May attended St. Bernard College and went on to teach school for 30 years. She is survived by her children, Ronnie (Judi) Wilson, David Wilson, Dana (Ken) Cunningham, and Rusty (Amanda) Wilson; and a host of grand children, friends, and family.



Lee Thompson

Lee Thompson (PS '96), age 48, of Alpharetta, GA, passed away peacefully on May 14, 2026, at Northside Hospital Forsyth, following a lengthy battle with cancer.

After high school, Lee graduated from the United States Military Academy at West Point, NY, in 2000. He proudly served his country for more than two decades, including five years in the United States Army and sixteen additional years in the Alabama Army National Guard, retiring with the rank of Lieutenant Colonel. His distinguished military career included 12-month deployments to Kuwait as an Air Defense Officer, service in Iraq during Desert Storm with the 7th Cavalry Regiment as a Forward Fire Control Officer, and two deployments to Afghanistan as an Engineer Officer. In recognition of his exemplary service, Lee received numerous military honors, including three Bronze Star medals and a Legion of Merit medal.

Following his military career, Lee worked as a VP, Senior Development Leader for Synchrony Financial. Outside of work, he greatly enjoyed traveling with his wife, Dedra, and spending time outdoors camping with his two sons. Those left to cherish his memory include his wife, Dedra Thomas; mother-in-law, Kathie Thomas; sons, Brennen Thompson and Graham Thompson; father, Carey Thompson; and sister, Brook McNew, along with other family and friends.

Alfred (Fred) Poggi (C '71) passed away on April 14, 2026 after a short illness with pancreatic cancer.

St. Bernard Happenings

Preserving Our Heritage: A Window of Opportunity for Historic St. Bernard

By Rev. Paschal Pautler, O.S.B.

Throughout the year, our extended St. Bernard family consistently answers the call to support our daily operations. Thanks to your unwavering generosity, this past year alone we welcomed five new monks to the monastery and provided 127 students with a St. Bernard education. That is no small feat!

If you would like to make a gift toward this long overdue project, please don't hesitate to be in touch. Contact Fr. Paschal at frpaschal@stbernardabbey.com or 256-255-5854.

This summer, however, we are looking toward a different kind of project—one that focuses on preserving the physical foundations of our campus.

St. Bernard is uniquely blessed with beautiful historic architecture. The Administration Building and Benedict Hall stand as two of our earliest and most iconic structures. While we have worked diligently over the years to maintain and improve these buildings, one notable area remains unaddressed: the original wooden windows.

Currently, many of the windows in these historic halls are rotted, leaking, and hold loose, cracked panes of glass. This deterioration is not just visually unattractive; it presents a genuine safety hazard for our students, coworkers, monks, and guests, especially during unpredictable Alabama thunderstorms.

The primary challenge we faced in addressing this was the financial reality. To fully replace all 350 windows, the estimated cost was exorbitant—over two million dollars!

Fortunately, after research and consultation, an incredible opportunity has emerged. We have identified highly skilled carpenters and painters capable of restoring these century-old windows to their original, pristine condition. Most importantly, they can complete this meticulous restoration work for 84% less than the cost of total replacement.

To restore our windows and preserve this piece of St. Bernard's history, our goal is to raise over $100,000. We hope to complete as many windows as possible before classes resume in August.

We invite our readers, alumni, and friends to partner with us in repairing and restoring these antique windows, windows through which we see the shining hills and beautiful woodlands of St. Bernard.





Alumni Reunion

June 26-28, 2026 (See details inside)

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Alumni News



Joey Shadowens (PS '25) had the distinguished privilege of being a keynote speaker at the University of South Carolina's AIAA conference, representing Project NIGHT (Nuclear Isotopic Gas Hall Thrusters) - University of Alabama – Huntsville



Piper Watson

Piper Watson, (PS '22), graduated Magna Cum Laude from Anderson University in Anderson, SC on May 8 with a BSN in nursing. She will be working as an orthopedic nurse at St. Francis Hospital in Greenville, SC.



Rose-Tafazoli Wedding Party

John Christian Rose (PS '20) married **Olivia Niya Tafazoli** (PS '18). On May 2, 2026 in the Abbey Church. The Wedding party consisted of many friends who met at St. Bernard Prep. **Nikolas Borths** (PS '21), **Caleb Guthery** (PS '20), **Ian Sidley** (PS '20), **Francisco Tona** (PS '21), **Joel Rose** (PS 25), **Mr. & Mrs. JC Rose**, **Mai Thy Nguyen** (PS '20), **Emma Tafazoli** (PS '20), **Amelia Tafazoli** (PS '24), Hannah Goymer and Lauren Elliott.



Dr. Graham Clark Sanders

Graham Clark Sanders (PS '17) graduated from UAB School of Optometry with a Doctor of Optometry degree on May 8, 2026. Dr. Sanders will be doing a residency in Primary Care and Ocular Disease at the Greenville, SC VA



David Kerber

Congratulations to **David Kerber**, recently named Assistant Principal at Waterloo School in Atwood, Ohio. David has been a teacher and Intervention Specialist at Waterloo for five years.

Congratulations



Scott Rutledge Woods

Andy and McKenzie Woods (PS '13 and '14) announce the birth of their son, **Scott Rutledge Woods** born November 12, 2026. Scott weighed 8lbs 4oz and measuring 20.5 " long. He is the grandson of St. Bernard's Sandi Bockhold and St. Bernard Prep's Carrie Woods. The family resides in Huntsville.



Grey family announces arrival of Olivia

Jake (PS '16) and Elizabeth Grey announce the arrival of their little girl, **Olivia**, who was born on May 10 and weighed 8 lbs 3 ounces and measured 21 inches long. She joins her big brother, Brooks, at their home in Cullman.